

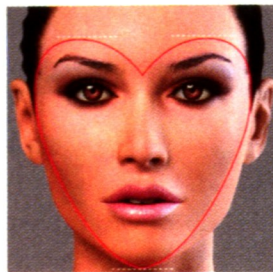
headed and self-possessed Ricky, who looks after his family's real estate and gas station businesses, found himself talking into the night and going home to tell his parents, "I think she might be the one." He proposed, Simran said "yes" and within six months they got married. "There was attraction from the start," says Simran. Scientists and psychologists studying the rules of attraction confirm that the very first flames of true love don't usually ignite without a physical spark. "We now know the secrets of attraction," informs London-based evolutionary psychologist, Dr Adrian Furnham from the University College London, who has co-authored *The Psychology of Physical Attraction* with colleague, Viren Swami.

But what causes that toes-a-tingling physical spark? "Sadly, it seems, humans really are as superficial as we seem," says Furnham. In study after study, good looks are increasingly showing up in the top five needs of the game of mating. Check out the new survey by Synovate, a global market research company, where 7,000 people across nine countries (including India) were asked how they measured attractiveness and what makes a person desirable: As many as 40 per cent said they would change their looks if they could; 30 per cent of Indians thought beauty products make a person more attractive; if money was no object, 46 per cent of women and a quarter of all men would spend big on branded facial and beauty products in the belief that these products would work their magic and one in five respondents said they would undergo plastic surgery if they had the money.

Beauty might be the key to romantic success, but not in the way singles on the dating scene equate being buff and beautiful as the clue to romantic success. The new science of attractiveness now argues that there are certain physical features of the body and face that are found attractive across all individuals and cultures. The unifying theme behind all of this new information is one common to biology: evolutionary fitness. "The rules of attraction are based on Darwinian theory," explains Furnham. "Men want mates who are fit and can reproduce healthy babies. So they look for and rate signs of youth, health and fertility." In recent years attention has focused on the female body because of the link with fertility, and researchers are identifying two potentially critical cues for attractiveness: Body shape and weight scaled for height, or Waist Hip Ratio (WHR) and Body Mass Index (BMI).

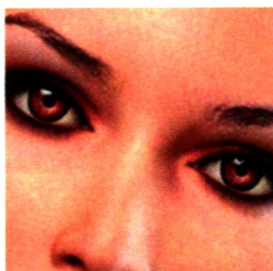
Women who make men go weak in the knees—Venus de Milo to Marilyn Monroe—are united by the fact that they all are blessed with a low waist-hip ratio. A theory first proposed by Indian psychologist, Devendra Singh, professor at the University of Texas, US, who analysed hourglass figures of *Playboy* models and Miss America contestants in the 1990s. To work out WHR, the waist measurement is divided by the hip measurement. Most women's WHR falls in the range of 0.7 to 1.0. The WHRs of 0.7 or 0.8

GO FIGURE The beauty of the female



Overall Shape

If you were to draw a pencil line, starting about half-an-inch above the eyebrows and ending at the tip of the chin, it should be a perfect heart shape.



Eyeing It Right

The width of the eye should be three-tenths of the face; distance from the centre of the eye to the bottom of the eyebrow should be one-tenth the height of the face.

Beautiful Theories

Perfect Symmetry

Is your left side a mirror image of your right side? Good symmetry shows that an individual has the genes to survive development and is a fertile choice for mating.

Hourglass Figure

Psychologists now focus on the waist-hip ratio as a major parameter of physical attractiveness. To work out WHR, the waist is divided by the hip measurement.

Weigh Up

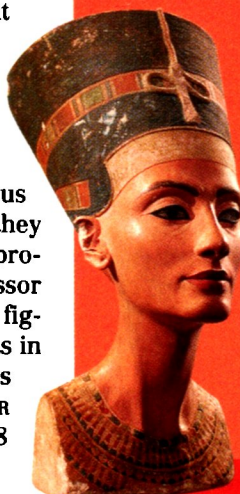
Body Mass Index is being hailed as the primary determinant. WHR effect is only evident when body weight is controlled.

Face Value

How we perceive beauty zeroes down to the face—large eyes, small nose and chin, high cheekbones and a wide smile.

Sniff This

How we smell is another factor. Chemical signals (pheromones) produced by the body communicate reproductive quality.



EGYPTIAN QUEEN NEFERTITI HAD THE IDEAL FACE